

Although most medical facilities will ask you what insurance you have before they make an appointment, it's your job to be absolutely sure the physician is within your network and what procedures you are allowed to have. Otherwise, you could be slapped with a big denial from your insurance company, and left owing a hefty bill.

I know the insurance manuals you get in the mail don't always read like an exciting novel, but one call to your insurance company and they are usually happy to walk through it with you. I like to take notes, clarify terms, and find out exactly what the deductible does and does not cover during the conversation.

I have referenced these notes many a time when doctors and hospital bills arrive in the mail, just to make sure all the amounts are correct. Depending on what's been covered, or if I have a question, I place another call to the insurance company. Sometimes the mistake has been on their end, and when they fix it, I get rebilled, or a nice little check in the mail!

2. NEGOTIATE AND PAY CASH

If you don't have health insurance, cash is the next viable option to pay for your visit. All doctors generally have a price sheet depending on the type of visit you have, so call around and get a variety of quotes before deciding which office to stop by. Just make sure that the doctor services uninsured patients. Some do, and some don't. Unlike hospitals, they're not required to by law.

When you confirm the average price for the doctor you're considering, call a couple insurance companies, or visit HealthCareBlueBook.com, and find out what they normally pay that doctor for that particular diagnosis. In case you were unaware, doctors charge far more per visit than they actually get paid—just one of the many secrets I learned while working for one!

With both amounts in hand, you're finally ready to negotiate a price for your visit. Be honest and see what price they can offer you before divulging your numbers. Most doctor's offices already have a discount they can offer